



Incident handler's journal

Date: 7/25/26	Entry: 1
Description	A ransomware attack on a small U.S. healthcare clinic caused major disruption to business operations, preventing employees from accessing critical patient files and medical records. This incident falls under the Detection and Analysis phase of the NIST Incident Response Lifecycle.
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	• Who: An organized group of unethical hackers known to target healthcare and transportation organizations • What: Employees received phishing emails with malicious attachments that installed ransomware, encrypting all critical files. A ransom note demanded payment for the decryption key. • When: Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m. • Where: A small U.S. healthcare clinic specializing in primary-care services • Why: Attackers exploited employees through targeted phishing emails. Lack of email security controls allowed the malicious attachment to be downloaded.
Additional notes	It would be important to determine whether the company had email filtering or security awareness training in place. Stronger MFA or endpoint protection may have prevented the attack.

Date: 7/25/26	Entry: 2
Description	Investigated a phishing alert at a financial services company involving a suspicious email with a malicious attachment. Used a phishing playbook to walk through the investigation and decided whether to escalate or close the ticket. Falls under Detection and Analysis.
Tool(s) used	Phishing playbook, SHA256 file hash verification
The 5 W's	• Who: An unknown attacker pretending to be a job applicant named Clyde West • What: A phishing email with a malicious executable file (bfsvc.exe) was sent to HR. The file hash was already confirmed as malicious. • When: Wednesday, July 20, 2022 at 9:30 a.m. • Where: The HR department of a financial services company • Why: The attacker disguised malware as a resume attachment and password-protected it to bypass email security scanning.
Additional notes	The ticket was escalated because the file hash was confirmed malicious, the sender's email domain looked suspicious, and the email had obvious grammatical errors. It's interesting how attackers use password protection on attachments specifically to avoid detection.

Date: 7/25/26	Entry: 3
Description	Used VirusTotal to look up a suspicious SHA256 file hash from a phishing alert to confirm whether the file was malicious. Falls under the Detection and Analysis phase.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	N/A
Additional notes	VirusTotal is a free tool that checks files and URLs against dozens of antivirus engines at once. I found it really useful because you can verify whether a file is malicious without actually running it. The hash I investigated came back flagged by multiple vendors, which made the escalation decision straightforward. I can see myself using this tool a lot in a real SOC environment.

Date: 7/25/26	Entry: 4
Description	Used Wazuh to run queries and analyze security event logs. This was my first time working with a SIEM tool hands-on and it gave me a much better understanding of how security monitoring works in practice. Falls under Detection and Analysis.
Tool(s) used	Wazuh

The 5 W's	N/A
Additional notes	Wazuh is a SIEM platform that collects and analyzes security event data from across an organization's systems. What I liked about it was being able to see alerts and logs in one place; it made it easy to understand how analysts spot patterns and anomalies. Before this I thought SIEM tools were intimidating, but working with Wazuh made it feel much more approachable.

Date: 7/25/26	Entry: 5
Description	Analyzed network packets to examine network traffic and identify potential security issues. Used tcpdump to capture and inspect packet data. This activity falls under the Detection and Analysis phase of the NIST Incident Response Lifecycle.
Tool(s) used	Tcpdump, WireShark
The 5 W's	N/A
Additional notes	tcpdump is a command line tool that captures network traffic in real time, while Wireshark provides a visual interface for analyzing packet data in detail. Working with these tools helped me understand how network traffic actually looks at the packet level. I can see how these tools would be incredibly valuable in a real investigation for tracing exactly what happened on a network during an

	incident.
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Reflections/Notes: Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?

The Linux file permissions activity was probably the most challenging for me at first. I wasn't very comfortable with the command line and kept second-guessing the syntax. But once I started running the commands and seeing the output change in real time, it started to click. It felt really satisfying to see the permissions update correctly.

Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?

Honestly yes, a lot. I used to think incident response was just about stopping attacks, but this course showed me it's a full structured process. The documentation side surprised me the most — keeping detailed records during an incident is just as important as the technical response, and that's something I didn't expect going in.

Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?

VirusTotal was probably my favorite. Being able to paste in a file hash and immediately see whether dozens of antivirus engines flag it as malicious felt like real analyst work. It's simple but incredibly powerful, and it showed me how much you can learn about a threat without ever having to touch the actual file.